

Why *kambankoozh* remains Tamil Nadu's favourite summer quencher

A glass of chilled *kambankoozh* beats the heat like nothing else. We try the fermented porridge at one of the oldest stalls in Coimbatore

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Kambankoozh, fermented pearl millet porridge served with curd and sliced onions in Coimbatore | Photo Credit: PERIASAMY M

At Pandiyan Brothers' *kambankoozh* stall that is under a mammoth copperpod tree, the summer heat is actually bearable. It is peak noon in April as I step away from the sweltering heat at Tatabad to join a clutch of people that mills about a pushcart near Power House. N Rajapandiyan is ladling thick, grey *kambankoozh*

into tall glasses, adding chilled curd and a smattering of chopped onions to each glass. Eager customers are quick to grab them and walk to a cosy corner nearby where another cart filled with sacks of colourful fryums awaits. The creamy *koozh*, punctuated by onions, its nutty flavour enhanced by the sourness of the curd, is pure bliss.

At Pandiyan Brothers Kambankoozh stall in Coimbatore | Photo Credit: PERIASAMY M

Kambankoozh carts are a common sight across the city. Now that summer is here, this fermented pearl millet porridge is a preferred choice for many who spend long hours in the sun. “Traditionally, people from Tamil Nadu primarily ate koozh and

kanji,” says Chennai-based M Seethalakshmi, a food researcher who focusses on traditional and forgotten recipes. “Our diet consisted of neer aagaram, food served in watery consistency. The vegetables our ancestors preferred too were those with a lot of water content in them,” she adds: “The first thing people had once they woke up in the morning was neechu thanni, water from soaking cooked rice the previous night.”

The stall also has ragi *kali*, butter milk, and karuppu kavuni *koozh* on the menu. | Photo Credit: PERIASAMY M

Seethalakshmi, who has researched on recipes inscribed on temple walls, says that *kambankoozh* has always been an important part of our food culture, especially during the summer months. *Koozh*, she adds, is a watery dish served once it ferments, as opposed to *kanji* that is had hot. “Kanji is more popular in Kerala, and is eaten during the monsoon and winter,” she adds.

N Rajapandiyar, who owns the Pandiyar Brothers Kambankoozh stall near the Power House at Tatabad, Coimbatore, has been making koozh for over 20 years. | Photo Credit: PERIASAMY M

While *kambankoozh* is available through the year — carts serve them in clay cups — it is during summer that many of us actually understand its potential to satiate

and quench at the same time. Rajapandiyan has been selling the porridge for over two decades and has earned a large following of regular customers.

At his stall, the mood is relaxed despite the swelling crowd, with the 37-year-old's smile never fading. His family came to Coimbatore to make a living from Alagapuri village near Madurai. Rajapandiyan did odd jobs — he worked as an office boy, plumber, electrician, helper, until he decided to join his father A Natarajan's humble *kambankoozh* stall in the same locality.

“He used to be a milkman, tending to cows and feeding them,” says Rajapandiyan. Pearl millet is among the main fodders for cows. “My father would cook the millet at night, mashing and mixing it with plenty of water to be offered to milch cows,” he explains. In the evenings, Natarajan sold *koozh* in a pushcart. He knew how to cook it well and also had access to quality curd since he was in the milk business.

N. Rajapandiyan makes kambankoozh in Coimbatore | Photo Credit: PERIASAMY M

Today, home-set curd is the defining factor in the *koozh* Rajapandiyan and his brother Jayapandiyan serve. “We ensure it is properly set and do not carry it over to the next day,” says Rajapandiyan. “This results in a koozh that is balanced and not too sour.” He also chops the onions fresh, selling a glass of *kambankoozh* for ₹30, and also has ragi *kali*, butter milk, and karuppu kavuni *koozh* on the menu.

Rajapandiyan also makes 200 litres of porridge to donate to those in need. He starts his day by offering *koozh* for visitors at the Government Hospital, wrapping

up for the day after distributing the dish to school children from two Government schools in Rathinapuri.

Preparations begin the previous evening, with the entire family pitching in. “I mash the cooked kambu by hand, adding the curd in the morning,” explains Rajapandiyan. According to celebrity chef K Damodaran, who has travelled extensively across rural Tamil Nadu to document recipes, one portion of pearl millet has to be cooked with four portions of water.

“In my younger years, the elders would make it a point to make kambankoozh once a week,” he recalls, adding, “More so in the summer since it cools the body down.” He prefers to pair it with a curry made of dry fish, brinjal and field beans. “Having it plain with just fresh curd is the best way,” says Damu. “One can also add ragi and rice to the porridge,” he explains. “This is usually served during the five weeks of the month of Aadi at Maariamman temples.”

Meanwhile, the crowd shows no sign of letting up at Pandiyan’s as a fresh batch of curd arrives in a large pail. Rajapandiyan pours it into a long, steel container in which he will prepare more *koozh*. A handful of bikes and two cars pull over just then for their fix of the porridge. Two customers walk by to order five glasses for takeaway. Rajapandiyan gets to work: summer is his favourite part of the year.

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